

EIGHT YEARS AGO, the United Nations set the clock ticking on what then Secretary-General Ban Ki-Moon called a “people’s agenda”. One-hundred-and-ninety-three countries agreed to meet a set of 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and 169 targets by 2030.

And significant progress was made in some critical areas until 2019: extreme poverty declined considerably, under-five mortality fell by 49 per cent between 2000 and 2017, and most of the world’s population had access to electricity. But all of that came to a screeching halt in 2020 after the outbreak of the Covid-19 pandemic, and the situation got worse after Russia invaded Ukraine. So much so that the number of people living in extreme poverty today is higher than it was four years ago, hunger has increased to levels seen in 2005, gender equality is some 300 years away, and just 26 people own as much wealth as half of the world’s population, per the UN.

So, when the development ministers of the G20 nations met in Varanasi in June under India’s G20 presidency—almost exactly at the halfway mark to the 2030 deadline—they were painfully aware of that ticking clock. The stakes were high, and something had to be done to push the world back on track to meet those 17 goals. The result was the seven-year action plan drawn up by the G20 Development Working Group, referred to as India’s seven-year action plan—this is an extension to the 2016 Hangzhou Action Plan—that was presented during the G20 Development Ministers’ Meeting in Varanasi on June 12.

The action plan highlights three core agendas: harnessing data and digital technologies for development; implementing sustainable, inclusive, and just transitions globally while leaving no one behind (LNOB); and investing in gender equality and the empowerment of women.

THE AGENDA

Beyond those broad principles, the action plan acknowledges that “three years into what we hoped would be the ‘decade of action’ for achievement of the SDGs, with the reversal of years of progress on the SDGs, we still face the challenge of recovery”. The document goes on to say that it is becoming evident that achieving the SDGs requires coordination and alignment across policy areas and transformative actions that create multiplier effects. It is important, therefore, to understand just what it means by

MILES TO GO

- JUST 12 PER CENT OF SDGs ARE ON TRACK
- PROGRESS ON 50 PER CENT IS WEAK AND INSUFFICIENT
- PROGRESS ON MORE THAN 30 PER CENT SDGs HAS STALLED OR GONE INTO REVERSE

WORK IN PROGRESS

- PEOPLE LIVING IN EXTREME POVERTY HIGHER THAN IT WAS FOUR YEARS AGO
- HUNGER IS BACK AT 2005 LEVELS
- GENDER EQUALITY IS 300 YEARS AWAY
- INEQUALITY IS AT A RECORD HIGH: JUST 26 PEOPLE HAVE AS MUCH WEALTH AS HALF OF THE WORLD’S POPULATION

SOURCE UNITED NATIONS